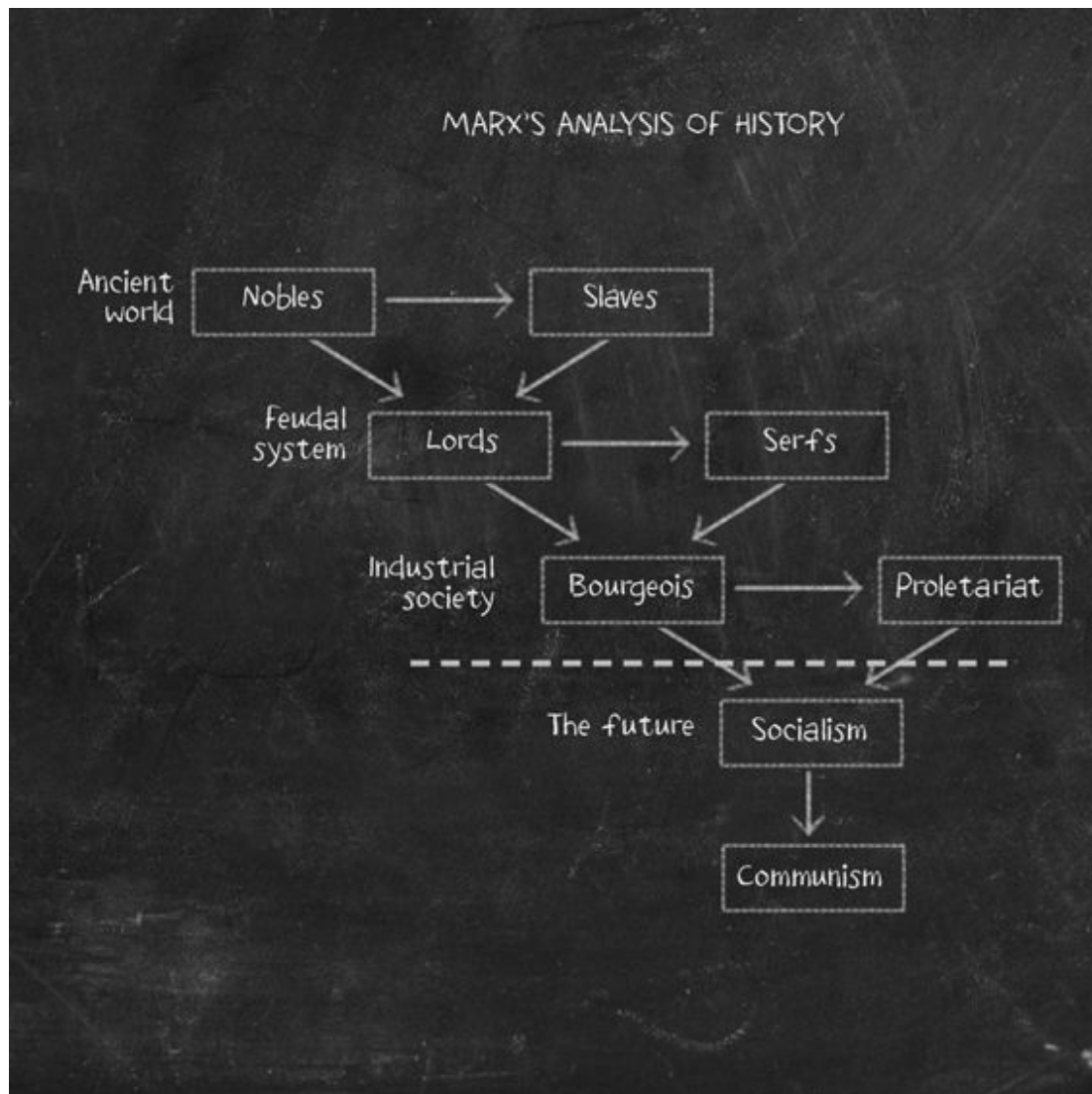


Dialectical materialism

As a student, Karl Marx became interested in the theories of Hegel, and especially the dialectic of historical progress. But, along with other left-wing 'young Hegelians', he saw the dialectic as a political and social process. Marx was a materialist and an admirer of Feuerbach, but came to reject the contemporary German preoccupation with metaphysics, famously declaring 'The philosophers have only interpreted the world, in various ways. The point, however, is to change it.'

By adopting the framework of Hegel's dialectic and applying it to his own ideas, Marx analysed the historical process in terms of social and economic relations rather than Spirit. In this dialectical materialism, contradictions of thesis and antithesis were those of the struggle between classes. From the thesis of feudal lords and antithesis of serfs, for example, came the synthesis of city life. Marx believed that philosophy could not only analyse history as a series of class struggles, but also provide a vision for future progress to a classless society.



In Marx's dialectical analysis of history, there is an inevitable progress from the injustice of the ancient world to an egalitarian future of communism.